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Dane County covers Flock Safety cameras amid privacy concerns

Lauryn Abozeid

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One of the 8 Flock cameras installed on UW-Madison's campus.

Dane County Sheriff's Office covers Flock Cameras

MADISON (WKOW) — Flock Safety's cameras in Dane County are now covered after the sheriff's office contract with the company expired at the end of May.

The sheriff's office took the extra step to ensure no additional data was collected while the cameras remained in place. Flock is planning to take down the cameras June 24.

Dane County Sheriff Calvin Barrett says concerns about privacy and reports out of nearby Verona prompted the decision to cover the cameras after the contract expired.

"Flock might have been collecting data after the conclusion of their contract, but personally or professionally, we did not have any information that led to that," Barrett said. "We knew that that was out there, and we wanted to make sure that no additional data was being collected."

While the contract with Flock has ended, Barrett says the technology itself remains important for public safety, especially in rural parts of Dane County.

"We have about 1,000 square miles of land that we have to cover with a minimal amount of deputies, and these cameras, or this technology plays an important role in making sure we can cover large parts of the community," Barrett said.

Barrett says automatic license plate reader technology has been part of what he calls a "recipe of success," helping contribute to reductions in several crime categories. The technology "has led to three year lows in some of our major categories of crime over the past three years," Barrett said.

The sheriff's office is now looking at other options.

Barrett says the office needs this technology but wants to be the only agency with access to it.

Flock Safety addressed the privacy concerns in a statement, saying

"Dane County's cameras were deactivated earlier this month and are no longer capturing data. When a contract ends or is cancelled, Flock works with the agency to coordinate deactivation and removal of the equipment."

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